

Lecture 11 Notes:

Aristotle's *Topics*, Book IV

Central Theme

Aristotle's *Topics*, Book IV gives commonplace rules for testing proposed genera.

<i>Topics</i> , Book IV = commonplace rules for testing proposed genera

Book IV teaches how to ask whether someone has placed a thing in the right kind.

A genus must be wider than the species, predicated in essence, in the same category, literally and synonymously said, accompanied by its higher genera, and not confused with accident, differentia, capacity, activity, metaphor, part, or mere accompaniment.

1. From Comparison to Genus

Book III taught rules for comparing goods.

Is A better or more desirable than B ?

Book IV returns to the predicables and asks about genus.

Is G really the genus of S ?

Whiteboard

Book III: comparison of goods

Book IV: testing proposed genera

Teaching Point

To test a genus is to test whether a thing has been placed in the right kind.

A false genus produces false classification.
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2. Why Genus Matters

A genus tells us what something is broadly.

species $\subset$ genus

man $\subset$ animal

The genus does not give the complete definition, but it gives the higher kind under which the species falls.

Teaching Point

A genus is predicated in the category of essence.

Genus says what a thing is broadly.

3. The Basic Genus Question

The basic question of Book IV is:

Is this proposed genus truly predicated of the species in essence?

That question can fail in many ways.

A proposed genus may really be:

- an accident,
- a quality,
- a relation,
- a metaphor,
- a differentia,
- a part,
- a capacity,
- an activity,
- a mere accompaniment.

Teaching Point

Book IV trains us to detect false classification.

Do not confuse what a thing is with what happens to belong to it.

4. First Test: Is the Genus Predicated of Every Member?

If a proposed genus does not apply to every member of the species, it is not the genus.

G is genus of $S \Rightarrow G$ belongs to every S

some S is not $G \Rightarrow G$ is not the genus

Example

Suppose someone says:

good is the genus of pleasure.

Then ask:

Is some pleasure not good?

If some pleasure is not good, then good is not the genus of pleasure.

Teaching Point

One species-member outside the proposed genus refutes the genus.

A true genus is predicated of all members of the species.

5. Second Test: Essence or Accident?

A proposed genus must be predicated in the category of essence, not merely as an accident.

Example: Snow and White

snow is white

But:

snow is not a kind of white

White is a quality of snow, not the genus of snow.

Example: Soul and Self-Moved

soul may be self-moved

But:

soul is not a kind of moving object

Motion is not the essence of soul.

Teaching Point

A genus says what a thing is, not merely what happens to belong to it.

Accidental predication is not generic predication.
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6. Use the Definition of Accident

An accident is what can belong or not belong to the same thing.

Accident = can belong or not belong

A genus does not come and go while the species remains.

Genus = belongs as long as the species exists

Examples

A thing may be white or not white.

A thing may be self-moved or not self-moved.

Therefore, whiteness and self-motion are accidents, not genera, in these cases.

Teaching Point

What can come and go cannot be the genus.

A genus belongs to the species essentially, not intermittently.

7. Genus and Species Must Be in the Same Category

The genus and species must fall under the same categorical division.

If the species is a substance, the genus must be a substance.

If the species is a quality, the genus must be a quality.

If the species is a relative, the genus should be a relative.

Examples

Snow and swan are substances.

White is a quality.

Therefore:

white is not the genus of snow or swan.

Knowledge is a relative.

Good and noble are qualities.

Therefore:

good and noble are not the genus of knowledge.

Teaching Point

A genus must live in the same categorical division as its species.

Category mismatch refutes a proposed genus.

8. Species Partake of Genera

To partake of something is to admit its definition.

A species partakes of its genus because the definition of the genus applies to the species.

species partakes of genus

But the genus does not partake of the species.

genus does not partake of species

Example

Man admits the definition of animal.

man $\rightarrow$ animal

But animal does not admit the definition of man.

animal $\nrightarrow$ man

Teaching Point

The genus is wider than the species.

Partaking runs upward from species to genus, not downward from genus to species.

9. The Genus Must Be Wider Than the Species

The genus has wider denotation than the species and the differentia.

$$\text{genus} > \text{species}$$

If the proposed genus has equal or narrower extension, it is not the genus.

$$\text{equal extension} \Rightarrow \text{not genus/species}$$

$$\text{narrower extension} \Rightarrow \text{not genus}$$

Example

Being and Unity are predicated of everything.

So neither can be the genus of the other in the ordinary way.

$$\text{Being} = \text{Unity in extension}$$

$$\therefore \text{neither is the genus of the other}$$

Teaching Point

If the proposed genus is not wider than the species, it is not a genus.

$$\text{Wider extension is a mark of genus.}$$

10. Species Wider Than Genus Reverses the Order

If the species has wider denotation than the proposed genus, the classification has been reversed.

Example

Object of opinion is wider than being, because both what exists and what does not exist may be objects of opinion.

$$\text{object of opinion} > \text{being}$$

Therefore, being cannot be the genus of object of opinion.

Teaching Point

The genus must include the species, not be included by it.

A narrower term cannot be the genus of a wider one.

11. If the Genus Applies, Some Species of the Genus Must Apply

If a thing is placed under a genus, it must fall under one of the species generated by the first division of that genus.

$$S \subset G \Rightarrow S \subset \text{some species of } G$$

Example

Suppose someone says:

motion is the genus of pleasure.

Then pleasure must be some species of motion.

pleasure = locomotion, alteration, growth, diminution, or another species of motion

If pleasure is none of these, then motion is not its genus.

Teaching Point

A generic claim must be cashed out in the genus's proper divisions.

If no species of the genus applies, the genus does not apply.

12. Things Not Specifically Different Should Have the Same Genus

All things that are not specifically different have the same genus.

$$\text{not specifically different} \Rightarrow \text{same genus}$$

If a proposed genus applies to one but not another thing not specifically different, the genus claim fails.

Teaching Point

A genus cannot arbitrarily split things that are not specifically different.

Sameness of species requires sameness of genus.

13. Multiple Genera Must Be Ordered

If one species falls under two genera, then the genera should be ordered.

Either:

$$G_1 \subset G_2$$

or:

$$G_2 \subset G_1$$

or both fall under a higher genus:

$$G_1, G_2 \subset H$$

Example

If justice is said to be both knowledge and virtue, then we must ask how knowledge and virtue are related.

Are they subordinate to each other?

Do they both fall under some higher genus, such as state or disposition?

Teaching Point

A species cannot be placed under unrelated genera without explanation.

Genuine classification requires ordered genera.

14. Higher Genera Must Also Be Predicated in Essence

If a proposed genus is truly the genus of a species, then its higher genera must also be predicated of the species in the category of essence.

$$S \subset G \subset H \subset I$$

G, H, I must all be predicated essentially of S

Example

If animal is the genus of man, then living thing and substance must also be predicated essentially of man.

$$\text{man} \subset \text{animal} \subset \text{living thing} \subset \text{substance}$$

Teaching Point

A true genus brings its higher genera with it.

Look upward through the hierarchy to test the proposed genus.

15. If a Higher Genus Fails, the Lower Genus Fails

If any higher genus of the proposed genus fails to be predicated essentially of the species, the proposed genus is false.

Pattern

$$S \subset G \subset H$$

If:

H is not essentially predicated of S

then:

G is not the genus of S

Teaching Point

The chain of essence cannot break above the proposed genus.

A false higher genus exposes a false lower genus.

16. Test the Things of Which the Species Is Predicated

If the given species is itself predicated of other things, then the proposed genus must also be predicated essentially of those things.

Pattern

If:

$$A \subset S$$

and:

$$S \subset G$$

then:

$$A \subset G$$

Teaching Point

Whatever falls under the species should also fall under the species' genus.

The genus follows the species down to its instances.

17. Definitions of Genera Must Apply to the Species

The definition of the genus must apply to the species and to the things that partake of the species.

definition of G applies to S

definition of G applies to instances of S

Teaching Point

It is not enough for the name of the genus to apply; its definition must also apply.

A true genus is predicated synonymously, with its definition.

18. Do Not Render Differentia as Genus

A differentia should not be treated as a genus.

Example

Do not call immortal the genus of God.

God = living being + immortal

Here:

genus = living being

differentia = immortal

Immortal tells what sort of living being, not the broad kind itself.

Teaching Point

The genus tells the broad kind; the differentia tells what sort within that kind.

Differentia qualifies the genus; it is not itself the genus.

19. Do Not Place the Differentia Inside the Genus as Species

A differentia is not a species of the genus it divides.

Example

Odd is not a species of number.

odd $\neq$ a number

Rather:

odd = differentia of number

Odd divides numbers into a kind.

Teaching Point

A differentia divides a genus; it is not itself a species under that genus.

Differentiae are not species or individuals.

20. Do Not Place Genus Inside Species

Sometimes a person places the genus inside the species by mistake.

Examples

Rather: $\text{contact} \neq \text{junction}$

but not: $\text{junction} \Rightarrow \text{contact}$

Likewise: $\text{contact} \Rightarrow \text{junction}$

and: $\text{mixture} \neq \text{fusion}$

$\text{locomotion} \neq \text{carriage}$

Teaching Point

If the supposed species is wider than the supposed genus, the classification is reversed.

Misordered extension exposes false genus claims.
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21. Do Not Place Species Inside Differentia

The species should not be treated as if it were inside the differentia.

Example

Do not say:

$\text{immortal} = \text{a god}$

Immortal has wider denotation than God, because other living beings might be called immortal in some context.

Teaching Point

The differentia is at least as wide as the species it marks.

Species is not the genus of its own differentia.
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22. Do Not Place Genus Inside Differentia

The genus should not be placed inside the differentia.

Examples

Do not define colour as what pierces the vision if piercing is a differentia.

Do not define number as what is odd.

number $\neq$ odd

Odd is a way of dividing number, not the genus of number.

Teaching Point

The genus has wider denotation than its differentia and does not partake of its differentia.

The genus is not contained inside one of its divisions.

23. Genus and Differentia Must Accompany the Species

If a proposed genus or differentia can be absent from the alleged species while the species remains, it is not really the genus or differentia.

$S \text{ exists} \Rightarrow G \text{ present}$

$S \text{ exists} \Rightarrow D \text{ present}$

Example

If movement can be absent from the soul, then movement is not the genus of soul.

If truth and falsehood can be absent from opinion, then they are not its differentia.

Teaching Point

The genus and differentia do not come and go while the species remains.

Essential constituents accompany the species as long as it exists.

24. The Species Must Not Partake of a Contrary Genus

If the species can partake of a contrary of the proposed genus, the proposed genus fails.

Pattern

$$S \subset G$$

$$S \subset \text{contrary of } G$$

$$\therefore G \text{ is not the genus of } S$$

Teaching Point

A thing cannot essentially belong under contrary genera at the same time.

Contrary genera expose false classification.

25. The Species Must Not Have What the Genus Cannot Have

If the species has a feature impossible for any member of the proposed genus, then the proposed genus is false.

Example

If the soul shares in life, while no number can live, then soul cannot be a species of number.

soul has life

number cannot have life

$\therefore$ soul is not a number

Teaching Point

A proposed genus fails if the species has features impossible within that genus.

The species must be possible within the nature of the genus.

26. Genus and Species Must Be Synonymous, Not Homonymous

A true genus is predicated synonymously of its species.

That means the name and the definition apply in the same sense.

true genus = synonymous predication

Mere shared naming is homonymy.

mere shared word = homonymy

Teaching Point

A genus must be predicated in the same sense, not merely with the same word.

Homonymy is not classification.

27. A Genus Must Have More Than One Species

Every genus has more than one species.

genus $\Rightarrow$ multiple species

If it is impossible for there to be another species besides the one given, then the proposed term is not really a genus.

Teaching Point

A genus is a common kind, not a private label for one species.

Where there is no possible division into species, there is no genus.

28. Do Not Use Metaphor as Genus

A metaphorical expression should not be used as a genus.

Example

Do not define temperance as a harmony.

temperance is a harmony

This may be metaphorically suggestive, but it is not literal classification.

Teaching Point

A genus must classify literally, not poetically.

Metaphor is not genus.

29. Use Contraries to Test Genus

Contraries provide tests for proposed genera.

If the genus has no contrary, then contrary species should be in the same genus.

$$S \text{ and contrary } S' \subset G$$

If the genus has a contrary, then the contrary species should be found in the contrary genus.

$$S \subset G$$

$$S' \subset G'$$

Example

If virtue and vice are contrary genera, then justice and injustice should fall under them respectively.

$$\text{justice} \subset \text{virtue}$$

$$\text{injustice} \subset \text{vice}$$

Teaching Point

Contrary species should be located according to the contrary structure of their genera.

Contrary structure should be preserved across genus and species.

30. Intermediates Must Fit the Same Structure

If contraries have intermediates, their genera should have intermediates in a corresponding way.

Likewise, if the genera have intermediates, the species should have intermediates in a corresponding way.

Example

Virtue and vice have intermediates.

Justice and injustice have intermediates.

The structures correspond.

Teaching Point

The structure of extremes and intermediates should be preserved across genus and species.

A proposed genus should preserve the opposition-structure of the species.

31. Co-Ordinates and Inflected Forms

Aristotle recommends looking at co-ordinates and inflected forms.

Example

If justice is a kind of knowledge, then:

justly = knowingly

and:

the just man = a man of knowledge

If any of these related expressions fails, the genus claim is weakened.

Teaching Point

A genus claim should hold across the family of related expressions.

Test the genus through its linguistic relatives.

32. Likenesses and Analogies

Aristotle also uses likenesses.

Example

pleasant : pleasure = useful : good

If pleasure is a kind of good, then the pleasant may be treated as a kind of useful.

Teaching Point

Analogous relations can transfer pressure onto a proposed genus.

Analogy gives a route for testing genus, but not an automatic proof.

33. Generation, Destruction, Capacities, and Uses

The same analogical testing applies to:

1. processes of generation
2. processes of destruction
3. things that generate
4. things that destroy
5. capacities
6. uses

Examples

If to build is to be active, then to have built is to have been active.

If learning is recollection, then having learned is having recollected.

If a capacity is a disposition, then to be capable is to be disposed.

Teaching Point

A genus claim should remain stable across related processes, products, capacities, and uses.

The same classification should survive across the term's natural family.

34. Privation and Possession

If the opposite of the species is a privation, one can test whether that privation falls under the opposite genus.

Example

If blindness is a form of insensibility, then sight is a form of sensation.

$$\text{blindness} \subset \text{insensibility}$$
$$\therefore \text{sight} \subset \text{sensation}$$

Teaching Point

Privation and possession can test whether a genus relation is properly paired.

The positive and privative forms should belong under corresponding genera.

35. Use Negation by Converting the Order

If the species falls under the genus, then whatever is not the genus is not the species.

$$S \subset G \Rightarrow \neg G \Rightarrow \neg S$$

Example

If the pleasant is a kind of good, then what is not good is not pleasant.

$$\text{pleasant} \subset \text{good}$$

$$\text{not good} \Rightarrow \text{not pleasant}$$

Teaching Point

If the genus is denied, the species must be denied.

A species cannot appear where its genus is absent.

36. Relative Terms and Their Genera

If the species is a relative term, the genus is usually expected to be relative as well.

Example

$$\text{double} \subset \text{multiple}$$

Both are relative terms.

$$\text{double of something}$$

$$\text{multiple of something}$$

Teaching Point

Relative species should fit the relational grammar of their genera.

Relatives bring their correlates with them.

37. Same Relational Use

If the species is used in relation to something, the genus should be used in a corresponding relation.

Example

If double means double of a half, then multiple should also be used in relation to that same correlate.

double of $X \Rightarrow$ multiple of X

Teaching Point

A proposed genus should preserve the relational pattern of its species.

Genus and species should have compatible relational grammar.

38. Case-Relationships and Constructions

Aristotle also examines grammatical constructions.

If genus and species are truly related, their constructions should often match.

Examples

We say:

double of something

and:

multiple of something

We say:

knowledge of something

and:

object of knowledge

Teaching Point

The grammar of a term can reveal whether it belongs under the proposed genus.

Logical relations often show themselves in linguistic constructions.

39. Different Kinds of Relatives

Some relative terms must be found in the things to which they are related.

Others may be found there but need not be.

Others cannot be found there at all.

Examples

A state or disposition is found in the thing whose state or disposition it is.

An object of knowledge may be known by a soul, but need not itself contain the knowledge.

A contrary is not found in its contrary.

Teaching Point

Do not place a relative term under a genus that has the wrong relational mode.

Relatives must be classified according to how they relate to their correlates.

40. State and Activity

Aristotle warns against placing a state in the genus of activity, or an activity inside the genus of state.

state $\neq$ activity

Example

If sensation is a state, it should not be defined as movement through the body.

sensation $\neq$ movement through the body

Teaching Point

A proposed genus fails if it places the thing in the wrong mode of being.

State and activity must not be confused.

41. Capacity and State

A state should not be ranked within the capacity that attends it.

Examples

Do not define good temper as control of anger.

Do not define courage as control of fears.

Do not define justice as control of gains.

Teaching Point

Virtue is not mere control-capacity.

A stable excellence is not the same as the ability to resist passion.

42. Virtue and Self-Control

The courageous or good-tempered person is not merely the person who feels passion and controls it.

Rather, the virtuous person is properly ordered with respect to those passions.

The self-controlled person still has contrary passions, but resists them.

self-control $\neq$ virtue

control of passion $\neq$ proper ordering of passion

Teaching Point

Do not mistake an accompanying capacity for the genus of a virtue.

Virtue is deeper than resistance.

43. Do Not Mistake Attendant Features for Genera

An attendant feature is not necessarily a genus.

Example: Anger and Pain

Pain may accompany anger.

But anger is not a species of pain.

anger has pain $\neq$ anger is pain

Example: Conviction and Conception

Conception may accompany conviction.

But conviction is not a species of conception.

One may have the same conception without being convinced of it.

Teaching Point

What accompanies a thing need not state what the thing is.

Accompaniment is not essence.

44. Genus and Species Must Occur in the Same Subject

If a genus truly contains a species, then what contains the species should also contain the genus.

contains species $\Rightarrow$ contains genus

Example

If shame is fear, then shame and fear should occur in the same faculty.

But shame is found in the reasoning faculty, while fear is found in the spirited faculty.

Therefore, shame is not fear.

Example

If anger is pain, then anger and pain should occur in the same faculty.

But pain is found in the faculty of desire, while anger is found in the spirited faculty.

Therefore, anger is not pain.

Teaching Point

A genus and its species must naturally belong in the same subject.

Different natural locations expose false genus claims.

45. Genus Is Not Imparted Only in a Respect

A genus is not said of its species merely in a particular respect.

genus belongs simply

not:

genus belongs only in a respect

Example

A man is not an animal merely in respect of his body.
He is animal simply.

False Genus Example

Animal should not be defined as object of sight.
An animal is visible only in respect of its body, not in respect of its soul.

Teaching Point

A genus belongs to its species without qualification.

Qualified predication is not generic predication.

46. Do Not Place Whole Inside Part

Sometimes people place the whole inside the part.

Example

Animal is sometimes defined as:

animate body

But body is a part of animal.
A part is not predicated of the whole in the way a genus is.

body = part of animal

part $\neq$ genus of whole

Teaching Point

A part is not the genus of the whole.

Material component and genus are not the same relation.

47. Capacity Is Not the Genus of Blameworthy Things

Do not put blameworthy things into the genus of capacity.

Example

A thief is not simply:

one capable of stealing

Even a good man may be capable of doing evil.

Bad people are named bad because of choice, not mere capacity.

bad character $\rightarrow$ choice

not mere capacity

Teaching Point

Blame attaches to choice, not bare capacity.

Capacity can be neutral or desirable; vice involves choice.

48. Intrinsic Goods Are Not Mere Capacities

Things precious or desirable for their own sake should not be placed in the genus of capacity, capability, or productivity.

Capacity and productivity are desirable for the sake of something else.

capacity = for the sake of another

precious for itself $\neq$ mere capacity

Teaching Point

Intrinsic goods should not be reduced to instrumental powers.

What is desirable for itself is not merely productive of something else.
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49. Some Things Require More Than One Genus

Some things cannot be placed in a single genus.

Example

A cheat or slanderer requires both will and capacity.

cheat = will + capacity

A person with will but no capacity is not yet a cheat.

A person with capacity but no will is not yet a cheat.

Teaching Point

Some classifications require combined genera rather than a single genus.

Complex characters may require more than one explanatory source.

50. Do Not Reverse Genus and Differentia

Sometimes people render genus and differentia in converse order.

Examples

astonishment = excess of wonderment

conviction = vehemence of conception

Here, wonderment and conception are the genera.

Excess and vehemence are differentiae.

genus = wonderment

differentia = excessive

Teaching Point

Do not turn the modifier into the genus.

The base kind is genus; the modifying intensity is differentia.

51. Absurd Results of Reversal

If excess were the genus of astonishment, then astonishment would be found in excess.

This would lead to strange expressions such as:

excessive excess

If vehemence were the genus of conviction, then conviction would be found in vehemence, leading to:

vehement vehemence

Teaching Point

A false genus often produces absurd predications.

Test a genus by the consequences of its wording.
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52. Affection Is Not the Affected Object

Do not put an affection into the affected object as its genus.

Example

Immortality should not be defined simply as everlasting life if immortality is an affection or feature of life.

immortality $\neq$ life

Rather:

immortality = a feature of life

Teaching Point

An affection of a thing is not the genus of the thing affected.

Do not confuse a feature with the subject that bears it.
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53. Movement Is Not the Moved Subject

Do not define an affection by the object of which it is an affection.

Example

Wind should not be defined simply as:

air in motion

Rather, wind is better understood as:

movement of air

The same air persists whether moving or still.
So wind is not simply air.

Other Examples

Snow is not simply water.
Mud is not simply earth.
Wine is not simply fermented water.

Teaching Point

Do not confuse movement or alteration with the subject moved or altered.

The affected subject is not automatically the genus of the affection.

54. A Term That Is Genus of Nothing Cannot Be This Genus

If a proposed term is not the genus of anything at all, it cannot be the genus of the species in question.

Example

White is not the genus of anything if white objects do not differ specifically from one another as species of white.

Teaching Point

A genus must be capable of containing species that differ in kind.

If there are no species under it, it is not a genus.

55. Beware Universal Predicates as Genera

Do not name as genus or differentia some feature that follows everything.

Examples

Being

Unity

These follow everything.

If Being were a genus, then everything would be a species of Being.
This collapses the genus-species relation.

Teaching Point

A predicate too universal to divide into species is not a usable genus.

What follows everything cannot function as an ordinary genus.

56. Genus Is True Of, Not Merely Inherent In

The genus is said to be true of the species.

An accident is said to be inherent in the subject.

Example

White is inherent in snow.

But white is not true of snow as genus.

white inherent in snow $\neq$ white genus of snow

Teaching Point

The grammar of genus differs from the grammar of accident.

Genus is predicated of what the species is, not merely found in it.

57. Better Species Should Not Be Placed in Worse Genera

If species and genus both have contraries, beware placing the better species inside the worse genus.

Pattern

better species $\rightarrow$ better genus

worse species $\rightarrow$ worse genus

Example

If soul is defined as a form of motion, this may be suspect because soul is also a principle of rest.

If rest is better than motion, then soul should not be placed under the worse side.

Teaching Point

The rank of contraries should be preserved across genus and species.

Better things should not be classified under worse genera.

58. Greater and Less

Use greater and less degrees to test a proposed genus.

If the proposed genus admits more and less, the species and terms derived from it should also admit more and less.

G admits more/less $\Rightarrow S$ should admit more/less

Example

If virtue admits greater and lesser degrees, then justice and the just man should also admit greater and lesser degrees.

more virtuous

more just

Teaching Point

Degree behavior should be compatible between genus and species.

If the genus varies by degree, its species should fit that pattern.

59. More Likely Genera

When several predicates seem to be predicated in the category of essence, and it is unclear which is the genus, compare the more likely candidates.

If the more likely candidate is not the genus, then the less likely one is not the genus either.

more likely fails $\Rightarrow$ less likely fails

If the less likely candidate is a genus, then the more likely one is also a genus.

less likely succeeds $\Rightarrow$ more likely succeeds

Teaching Point

Comparative plausibility can test uncertain genus claims.

More-and-less reasoning applies even to classification.

60. More Likely Species

The same method applies to species.

If two things have a like claim to be species of a genus, then if one is a species, so is the other.

If the less likely one is a species, the more likely one is also a species.

Teaching Point

Comparable cases should be treated consistently.

If the weaker case qualifies, the stronger case qualifies as well.

61. Establishing a Genus by Multiple Species

To establish a genus, see whether the genus is predicated in the category of essence of several different species.

If it is, then it is clearly functioning as a genus.

Pattern

$$S_1 \subset G$$

$$S_2 \subset G$$

$$S_3 \subset G$$

$\therefore G$ is a genus

Teaching Point

A genus shows itself by essential predication across multiple species.

The genus is common essence across different species.

62. Distinguishing Genus from Differentia

Aristotle gives direct criteria for distinguishing genus and differentia.

1. The genus has wider denotation than the differentia.
2. In stating essence, genus is more fitting than differentia.
3. Differentia signifies a quality of the genus.

Example

Calling man an animal better states what man is than calling him walking.

animal = genus

walking = quality or differentia-like feature

Teaching Point

Genus names the kind; differentia qualifies the kind.

Genus tells what it is; differentia tells what sort of that kind it is.

63. Establishing Genus Through Activity

If a term is a kind of activity or state, examine whether the subject, in doing the relevant action, is doing what belongs to the proposed genus.

Example

To show that knowledge is a form of conviction, ask whether the knower, in knowing, is convinced.

knowing $\Rightarrow$ being convinced

If so, knowledge may be treated as a kind of conviction.

Teaching Point

Sometimes genus is tested by what the subject is doing in the act named.

Examine the activity to test the classification.

64. What Always Follows Is Not Necessarily Genus

Something may always follow a thing without being its genus.

G genus of $S \Rightarrow G$ always follows S

But:

G always follows $S \not\Rightarrow G$ genus of S

Examples

Rest always follows calm.

Divisibility follows number.

But not every constant follower is a genus.

Teaching Point

Constant accompaniment is not the same as genus.

What always follows may still fail to say what the thing is.

65. The Case of Coming-to-Be and Not-Being

Aristotle gives a sharp example.

Not-being always follows what is coming to be, because what is coming to be is not yet.

But not-being is not the genus of coming-to-be.

Why?

Because not-being has no species.

not-being follows coming-to-be

but:

not-being has no species

$\therefore$ not-being is not a genus

Teaching Point

A constant follower must still satisfy the requirements of genus.

Accompaniment alone cannot overcome failure to divide into species.

66. The Architecture of Book IV

Book IV moves through the following arc:

what genus is → genus vs. accident → same category → wider denotation

→ species must fit divisions → higher genera → genus vs. differentia → contraries and intermediates

→ co-ordinates and likeness → relative terms → state, activity, capacity → attendant features

→ whole and part → universal predicates → greater and less → constant accompaniment vs. genus

Teaching Point

Book IV is Aristotle's guide to avoiding false classification.

The central question is whether the proposed genus really names what the thing is broadly.

67. Summary of Main Ideas

1. Book IV gives commonplace rules for testing proposed genera.
2. A genus tells what something is broadly.
3. A true genus is predicated in the category of essence.
4. A proposed genus must apply to every member of the species.
5. A genus must not be confused with an accident.
6. Genus and species must belong to the same category.
7. The species partakes of the genus, but the genus does not partake of the species.
8. The genus must be wider than the species.

9. If the genus applies, some species of that genus must apply.
10. Things not specifically different should have the same genus.
11. If a species falls under multiple genera, those genera must be ordered.
12. A true genus brings its higher genera with it.
13. A differentia must not be treated as a genus.
14. A differentia divides a genus but is not itself a species.
15. The genus must not be placed inside the species or inside the differentia.
16. The genus and differentia must accompany the species as long as it exists.
17. A species cannot belong under contrary genera.
18. A species cannot have features impossible for the proposed genus.
19. Genus and species must be synonymous, not homonymous.
20. A genus must have more than one species.
21. Metaphor is not genus.
22. Contraries and intermediates help test whether a proposed genus is correct.
23. Co-ordinates, inflected forms, likenesses, and analogies can test genus claims.
24. Relative species should fit the relational grammar of their genera.
25. State, activity, capacity, and disposition must not be confused.
26. Virtue should not be reduced to mere control-capacity.
27. Attendant features are not genera.
28. Genus and species must occur in the same natural subject.
29. A genus belongs simply, not merely in a certain respect.
30. A part is not the genus of the whole.
31. Blameworthy things are not defined by bare capacity.
32. Intrinsic goods should not be reduced to instrumental powers.
33. Some complex characters require more than one genus.
34. Universal predicates such as Being and Unity cannot function as ordinary genera.

- 35. Greater-and-less reasoning can test genus claims.
- 36. Constant accompaniment is not the same as genus.

Final Framing

Topics, Book IV, teaches how to test whether a proposed genus really names what a thing is broadly.

Book IV is Aristotle's guide to avoiding false classification. A genus must be wider than the species, predicated in essence, in the same category, literally and synonymously said, accompanied by its higher genera, and not confused with accident, differentia, capacity, activity, metaphor, part, or mere accompaniment.

A genus is not what merely accompanies a thing, but what it is broadly.